



XFX GeForce 5200 (64 MB)

other hand, with games such as *Far Cry* and *HL2*, the 5200 proves to be more than enough for that few hours of weekend gaming.

The XFX GeForce FX 5200 256 MB and the XFX GeForce FX 5200 64 MB were the overall winners in this category not only because of their price but also because they performed well. These two get the Digit Best Buy Gold Award and the Best Buy Silver Award respectively.

GAMING CATEGORY LOW END VIDEO CARDS

This category was created keeping in mind the falling prices of last year's mid-category cards. An ATI 9600XT can now be purchased for Rs 10,000 or less depending on the

manufacturer. With the arrival of more high-end cards, these cards have now been pushed to the low performance category but are still not low enough to fit into the budget category. There were 15 cards in this category and the fight a tough one. Here is how they fared.

Their Features

Almost all the cards had similar features with some featuring dual DVI inputs. One thing that should be understood is that when you are paying more than Rs 10,000 to get a video card; the criteria should always be to look at their performance rather than the software bundled along. Dual monitor inputs were present on all these cards as was a video-out port.

The games that are bundled with the cards are limited and normally include demos from various games and some older games bundled with the card. In our comparisons, both the



Half-Life 2 on the XFX GeForce FX 5700 Ultra shows off extremely good visuals

Gigabyte cards included the same software, which was a game and PowerDVD5 software, but one video card was priced higher than the other.

This underlines our assertion that the software bundled acquires a secondary status to the performance of the card and in your buying decision, it should always be performance that counts and not the software or other features the manufacturer bundles.

How We Tested And Decided The Award Winners

We received 32 cards for our tests. The cards were differentiated into two explicit categories—Budget and Gaming. Gaming was further divided into three subsections—Low, Medium, and High.

We had two separate test beds for testing the cards. One was made specifically for testing the budget cards, and the other was for the Performance category. The budget category test bed consisted of a Pentium IV 3.2 GHz, with 512 MB DDR 400 Corsair TwinX memory modules, and a 120 GB Seagate SATA hard drive installed on an MSI 875-P NEO.

The Gaming test bed consisted of an AMD 64-FX 53 running on an MSI 6702E motherboard with a Seagate 40 GB ATA100 hard drive with 1GB Corsair TwinX memory modules.

The Budget category included cards that had the bare minimum clock and memory speeds and were crippled when compared with various DirectX 9 features present on the higher cards. The prices of these cards were also noted, since these were the lowest-priced ones across the category.

Tier 1 Tests

In the Tier 1 tests, we used three games and one synthetic benchmark. The games we used were *Doom 3*, *Half-Life 2*, and *Far Cry*, and as the synthetic benchmark we used 3Dmark 2003. In Tier 1, the games were run at three different resolutions—640 x 480, 800 x 600 and 1,024 x 768, and the synthetic benchmark was run at 800 x 600 and 1,024 x 768. The in-game settings were kept to Medium, and tri-linear filtering was turned on. The driver settings for the cards were set at the highest performance—whatever was possible. Vertical Sync, AA and AF were completely turned off.

Tier 2 Tests

In the Tier 2 tests, we used the above mentioned games as well as *Call Of Duty*, *Halo* and the synthetic benchmark 3Dmark 2005. For the Performance Low cards, we tested them on only two resolutions—1280 x 1024 (without AA or AF) and 1,024 x 768 (with and without AA; AF was off for all the tests.)

For the mid and the high-range cards, we tested them on the above mentioned resolutions and also at 1,600 x 1,200 (No AA, AF). Vertical sync was turned off, and in-game settings were kept at the maximum. 3Dmark 2005 was used with high-end chipsets (5900 and higher for nVidia, 9700 and above in the ATI camp). We also used *Need for Speed Underground*, and took screenshots from that game along with *Half-Life 2* and *Doom 3* for our image quality tests.

How We Awarded

Only Tier 1 tests were run on the Budget cards, and the scores were calculated. The highest performing cards were awarded the Digit Best Buy awards.

For the gaming cards, the Tier 1 tests were run on all the cards and a compiled result of the scores for each card was calculated. From the scores that we got, an average score was calculated to give us the best-performing cards in all three subcategories. These cards were then put through the Tier 2 tests. The product that scored the highest in the overall score was adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Gold Award for its category. The runner-up received the Digit Best Buy Silver Award.